Could AI Change the Price You Pay at the Store?

From: PBS NewsHour Mined: 2026-11-12 3 min read

Imagine you and a friend buy the exact same groceries from the same store, but your bill comes out higher. That is the worry behind a new look at how companies use **artificial intelligence** to set prices.

In one test, 400 shoppers bought the same 20 items from the same stores on Instacart. The prices were not the same. For some items, the difference was as much as 23 percent.

Lindsay Owens leads a **consumer** group called Groundwork Collaborative. She worked with researchers to study the test. Soon after the test became public, Instacart stopped it. The company said the tests raised concerns.

Owens says many companies are comfortable changing prices. Computer programs called **algorithms** can shift prices based on personal data.

Owens and Elizabeth Pancotti also studied 315 **patents**. They found Walmart patent ideas for technology that could link to a **smartwatch**. But Walmart executive Dan Bartlett said the company will not use a customer's personal information to set a price just for that person. The question now is how companies choose to use it.

Word Treasure

artificial intelligence -- Artificial intelligence is computer smarts that let machines learn and make choices like people do.

algorithms -- Algorithms are sets of rules a computer follows to make a choice or solve a problem.

patents -- Patents are papers that give an inventor the right to be the one who uses a new idea.

smartwatch -- A smartwatch is a watch you wear on your wrist that can run apps and track things about you.

consumer -- A consumer is a person who buys and uses things like food and clothes.

Background you need

Some stores use computer programs to help decide what things cost.

These programs can look at personal data and change prices for different shoppers.

That is why people are asking whether the same item should cost the same for everyone.

Break it down

WHO: Lindsay Owens, researchers, Elizabeth Pancotti, Instacart, Walmart executive Dan Bartlett, and shoppers.

WHAT: A study found that the same groceries bought from the same stores could cost different amounts for different shoppers.

WHERE: On Instacart, at the same stores where shoppers bought the same 20 items.

WHY: Companies use artificial intelligence and algorithms that can shift prices based on personal data.

Why it matters

The price you pay for snacks or groceries could change depending on who you are, so it matters to know how prices are set.

Test what you remember

1. What did the test of shoppers buying the same groceries show?

- (A) Only one shopper could buy the items
- (B) The prices were not the same for everyone
- (C) The groceries were all free
- (D) Everyone paid exactly the same price

2. How many shoppers took part in the test?

- (A) 100 shoppers
- (B) 400 shoppers
- (C) 20 shoppers
- (D) 315 shoppers

3. How big was the price difference for some items?

- (A) As much as 50 percent
- (B) As much as 5 percent
- (C) As much as 2 percent
- (D) As much as 23 percent

4. Who leads the consumer group Groundwork Collaborative?

- (A) Elizabeth Pancotti
- (B) An Instacart worker
- (C) Lindsay Owens
- (D) Dan Bartlett

5. What did Instacart do soon after the test became public?

- (A) It hired more shoppers
- (B) It stopped the test
- (C) It shared the test with more stores
- (D) It lowered all its prices

6. What did Dan Bartlett say Walmart will not do?

- (A) Use computer programs at all
- (B) Let shoppers use a smartwatch
- (C) Sell groceries online
- (D) Use a customer's personal information to set a price just for that person

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: D 4: C 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Lindsay Owens: Owens says many companies are comfortable changing prices.
2. Instacart: Instacart said the tests raised concerns.
3. Dan Bartlett of Walmart: Bartlett said Walmart will not use a customer's personal information to set a price just for that person.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):